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Week 5 – GEITE01X
Living in the IT Era

Digital Divide

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LEARNING OUTCOMES

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At the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

1. Explain the concept of the digital divide and understand how it refers to the gap access to and usage of digital technologies between different individuals, communities, and regions.
2. Recognize various factors that contribute to the digital divide, such as socio-economic status, geography, age, education level, and cultural barriers.
3. Assess the consequences of the digital divide on individuals and society, includin its effects on education, employment, economic opportunities, healthcare, and social interactions.
4. Students will explore different approaches and initiatives aimed at bridging the digital divide, such as improving digital infrastructure, providing digital literacy training, and promoting affordable access to technology.

WHAT IS DIGITAL DIVIDE?

- **Digital divide** refers to the gap between demographics and regions that have access to modern information and communications technology and those that don't. Though the term now encompasses the technical and financial ability to use available technology along with access (or lack thereof) to the internet, the gap it refers to is constantly shifting as technology develops.
- When the term was first used in the late 20th century, for example, it described the gap between those with cellphone access and those without.



UNDERSTANDING THE DIGITAL DIVIDE

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- The digital divide encompasses the technical and financial ability to utilize available technology, along with access (or a lack of access) to the internet.
- **Digital divides exist** between developed and developing countries, urban and rural populations, young and educated versus older and less educated individuals, and men and women.
- The **urban-rural** divide is the single biggest factor in the digital divide.



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It can be seen in many situations, such as:

- **Between countries** – Developed countries usually have better internet infrastructure than developing ones.
- **Within countries,** urban areas often have faster internet and better access than rural areas.
- **Across generations and education levels,** younger, more educated people tend to use technology more effectively than older or less educated people.
- **Between genders –** In some societies, men have more access to technology than women

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TYPES OF DIGITAL DIVIDE

1. **Access Divide (First-Level Digital Divide)**

   Differences in access to devices, internet connectivity, and ICT infrastructure.

2. **Skills Divide (Second-Level Digital Divide)**

   Differences in digital literacy, technical knowledge, and ability to use digital technologies effectively.

3. **Usage Divide (Third-Level Digital Divide)**

   Differences in how people use technology and the benefits they obtain from it.

4. **Gender Digital Divide**

   Differences between men and women in access to, use of, and benefits gained from digital technologies.

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TYPES OF DIGITAL DIVIDE

5. **Age-Based Digital Divide**

   Differences in technology adoption between younger and older populations.

6. **Geographic Divide**

   Differences between urban and rural areas in internet availability and quality.

7. **Socioeconomic Divide**

   Differences caused by income, education, and social status.

8. **Disability Divide**

   Barriers faced by persons with disabilities in accessing and using digital technologies.

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DIGITAL DIVIDE FACTORS

1



Economic
(income, affordability)

Low income and high costs of devices, internet, and data create barriers to access.

2



Educational
(literacy, digital skills)

Lower literacy levels and lack of digital skills limit the ability to use technology effectively.

3



Geographic
(urban-rural disparities)

People in rural and remote areas have less access to reliable internet and services.

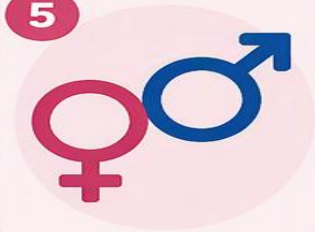
4



Age

Older adults may have lower rates of internet use and fewer digital skills compared to younger people.

5



Gender

Unequal access to technology between men and women due to social, cultural, and economic factors.

6



Social and cultural influences

Cultural norms, language barriers, and social attitudes can affect access to and use of digital technologies.

7



Infrastructure availability

Limited availability of electricity, broadband networks, and devices restricts connectivity and use.

8



Disability and accessibility

People with disabilities face additional barriers without accessible technologies and inclusive design.

9



Government policies and support

Policies, regulations, investments, and digital inclusion programs play a key role in bridging the divide.

The digital divide is shaped by multiple factors. Addressing these barriers together can create an inclusive digital world where everyone can connect, learn, and thrive.

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DIGITAL DIVIDE → KEY CONSEQUENCES

When some people lack access to digital technologies and skills, it leads to multiple disadvantages that affect individuals, communities, and society as a whole.

1



Educational disadvantage

Limited access to online learning, digital resources, and educational platforms. Students fall behind academically.

2



Economic inequality

Fewer job opportunities, limited access to digital skills training and remote work, leading to lower income potential.

3



Social exclusion

Difficulty participating in digital communication and social networks. Increased isolation from family and communities.

4



Information inequality

Limited ability to access news, government services, and important information. Greater risk of misinformation.

5



Healthcare barriers

Reduced access to telemedicine, online health information, and digital health services. Challenges in timely care.

6



Reduced civic engagement

Difficulty engaging in online government services, public consultations, and civic activities. Less awareness of public policies and initiatives.

7



Wider income disparities

Technology users gain more educational and economic benefits. Existing inequalities become more pronounced.

8



Lower business opportunities

Businesses may struggle to access e-commerce, digital markets, and new customers. Lower productivity and innovation.

9



Increased marginalization

Certain groups—such as rural populations, older adults, women, and persons with disabilities—become increasingly disadvantaged in a digital society.

OVERALL IMPACT: The digital divide reinforces existing inequalities and limits individuals' ability to fully participate in education, employment, healthcare, and society.

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Effects of the Digital Divide on Individuals

- Limited Access to Information and Opportunities
- Educational Disparities
- Employment and Economic Impact
- Social Isolation
- Health Disparities
- Civic Engagement



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Effects of the Digital Divide on Individuals

- Widening Inequality
- Education Gap
- Economic Productivity
- Social Cohesion
- Health Disparities
- Democratic Participation



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Bridging the Digital Divide

- In recent years, programs have been launched that aim to combat aspects of the digital divide. Many of these are being coordinated at the highest level, including within the U.N.'s Sustainable Development Goal (SDG), which allows individual countries to coordinate their activities toward ending digital discrimination.



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Bridging the Digital Divide

The **digital divide** can be reduced through coordinated efforts from governments, private sectors, schools, and communities. Key strategies include:

- Expanding Infrastructure
- Making Technology Affordable
- Improving Digital Literacy
- Ensuring Inclusive Access
- Supporting Education and Skills Development
- Promoting Government and Policy Support
- Encouraging Civic and Community Engagement



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Digital Divide Is A Curse!

Yes, the digital divide is a tremendous curse for modern society. Technology discrimination makes it harder for the poor and less resourceful people to get an adequate education to build a prosperous career.

Today, it is essential for governments and social organizations to come forward and take proactive steps to bridge the gap in digitalization. Likewise, educators and tech inventors need to collaborate and create learning resources to reach every student.

It will take some time to bridge the digital divide gap. But if every individual takes a step toward digitalization, we will have equal digital access worldwide in no time.

ACTIVITY My Perspective on the Digital Divide

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Instructions:

- Write a **1–2 page essay, 250-300 words** (or create a short infographic/poster if preferred) about the **digital divide**.
- Your work should include:
  - **Definition**: In your own words, explain what the digital divide means.
  - **Personal Experience/Observation**: Share an example where you saw or experienced the digital divide (at home, school, or in the community).
  - **Impact**: Explain how this digital gap affects people's education, work, or daily life.
  - **Solution**: Suggest at least one way to help reduce the digital divide.

Format:

- Handwritten or typed.
- Clear, simple, and organized.
- Use examples from real life (your own or what you observe around you).

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Key Approaches to Bridge the Digital Divide

Let's look at some immediate actions that can assist in removing technological discrimination from the world:

- Government Needs to Step Up
- More Digital Learning
- Digital Awareness
- Use Local Languages in Online Learning Materials
- Special Resources for Physically Incapable Students
- Address Social Issues



- https://www.investopedia.com/the-digital-divide-5116352
- https://www.splashlearn.com/blog/what-is-the-digital-divide-and-how-can-we-bridge-it/#4

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Thank you!

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